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The Effects of Target Characteristics on Public Support for Hate Speech Laws

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Abstract

Does the target of speech shape public support for hate speech laws? Regulating hate speech is controversial, partly because partisans are assumed to disagree over which groups such laws should protect. This article conducts a comprehensive test of how support for hate speech laws varies across partisan lines when speech targets ethnic, religious, gender, or political groups. Based on conjoint experiments in Denmark and the United States, the results show that support for regulation increases by up to 32 percentage points when severity increases from "incivility" to "incitement to violence." Target characteristics increase support for regulation by up to 6.3 percentage points and exert the strongest effects when speech targets ethnic and religious groups rather than gender or political groups. These effects persist when severity is held constant and are broadly stable across severity levels. They are also heterogeneous across partisan groups, mostly ranging from 3 to 7.2 percentage points, with one exception reaching 11.9 percentage points. In neither country are partisans more willing to regulate hate speech targeting their political opponents than hate speech targeting their political allies. Overall, severity has the strongest effect on support for hate speech regulation, while target characteristics have smaller, heterogeneous effects that are largest when speech targets ethnic or religious groups.

Keywords: Public opinion, Hate speech, Conjoint experiment, Regulation, Partisanship

Introduction

Does the target of speech shape public support for hate speech laws? Countries around the world are introducing laws that restrict hate speech (Parekh, 2012, p. 37) directed at groups based on target characteristics such as ethnicity, religion, and gender (Sellars, 2016, p. 25). Public opinion polls often indicate that partisans are polarized on restricting hate speech (Ekins, 2017, p. 14; Knight Foundation, 2024, p. 24; Poushter, 2015; Skaaning & Krishnarajan, 2025, p. 31). Nevertheless, existing evidence often relies on questions that do not make it possible to distinguish whether support for hate speech restrictions depends on *whom* the speech targets or on how severe it is.

To make valid inferences about public opinion on restrictions of civil liberties, scholars have recommended using a concrete context instead of abstract questions (Gibson & Gouws, 2001, pp. 1067–71, 1074; Petersen et al., 2011, pp. 581–85). This may be particularly important in the context of hate speech, as people can have different perceptions of what it is. As noted by Gagliardone et al. (2016, p. 7), "hate speech continues largely to be used in everyday discourse as a generic term, mixing concrete threats to individuals' and groups' security with cases in which people may be simply venting their anger against authority." Thus, a central challenge in measuring support for hate speech laws is to separate the target of the speech from its severity. Yet while hate speech laws have sparked considerable controversy (Howard, 2019, p. 94), empirical evidence on the extent to which ethnic, religious, gender, or political target characteristics shape people's support for such laws is limited.

The article addresses this shortcoming using two large conjoint experiments fielded in Denmark and the U.S., which make it possible to separate the effects of speech severity and

target characteristics on support for regulating hate speech. The design also permits an assessment of whether and to what extent specific target identities influence support for hate speech laws across partisan divides. Moreover, it extends existing work by systematically testing the most salient target characteristics. In short, this article conducts a comprehensive, cross-national test of how targeting people based on ethnicity, religion, gender, and political affiliation affects support for hate speech regulation.

The results show that severity and target characteristics have independent effects on support for hate speech regulation. Support for regulation increases by up to 32 percentage points in Denmark and 31 percentage points in the U.S. when severity changes from incivility to incitement to violence. The target of hate speech also affects support for regulation, although to a lesser degree. On average, support for hate speech regulation increases by up to 6.3 percentage points in Denmark and the U.S. The effects of target characteristics are strongest when hate speech targets ethnic or religious groups rather than gender or political groups, and the effects are broadly stable across levels of severity. Support for hate speech regulation also varies across partisan groups, as target characteristics have larger effects for some partisans when hate speech targets religious or ethnic minority groups. Among partisans, target characteristics affect support for hate speech laws by 3 to 7.2 percentage points, with one exception: among left-wing respondents in Denmark, support for regulation increases by 11.9 percentage points when statements target Muslims. Although the effects of target characteristics vary across partisans, the results also suggest substantial overlap in the extent to which target characteristics influence partisans' support for hate speech laws in the U.S. and Denmark.

The article also speaks to concerns about the adverse consequences of polarization in the U.S. Previous research shows that partisans can engage in selective censorship (Ashokkumar et al., 2020; Dias et al., 2025; Kubin et al., 2025; Lelkes & Westwood, 2016). This article finds little evidence that these preferences extend to hate speech restrictions, as partisans were neither more nor less willing to regulate hate speech targeting political opponents, allies, or people supporting particular political viewpoints.

Measuring Support for Hate Speech Restrictions

Hate speech laws are increasingly being introduced (Parekh, 2012, p. 37). According to Howard (2019, pp. 95–96), hate speech refers to "particular expressions of hatred against particular (groups of) people in particular contexts" on the basis of characteristics such as race, ethnicity, or religion (Sellars, 2016, p. 25). Yet hate speech is a broad and contested term that "continues largely to be used in everyday discourse as a generic term, mixing concrete threats to individuals' and groups' security with cases in which people may be simply venting their anger against authority" (Gagliardone et al., 2016, p. 7).

Scholars have highlighted the importance of assessing support for speech restrictions based on concrete judgments rather than abstract questions (Gibson & Gouws, 2001, pp. 1069–71, 1074). However, much existing evidence relies on measures that do not specify the level of severity and conflate multiple minority groups. For example, prior studies ask about speech that is "harmful or offensive to" (Doré et al., 2022), speech that "attacks people based on [characteristics]" (Knight Foundation, 2024), or speech that "offend[s] certain minorities or religious groups" (Chong et al., 2024, pp. 141–43; McClosky & Brill, 1983). Such measures therefore do not make it possible to isolate the effect of whom hate speech targets from the effect of its severity. As an illustrative example, a public opinion survey by YouGov and the Cato Institute compared support for hate speech laws across multiple ethnic and religious groups among partisans in the U.S. (Ekins, 2017, p. 14). Respondents in an American sample were asked, "Would you favor or oppose a law that would make it illegal to say offensive or insulting things in public about [African Americans/Christians/Muslims/White people]?" The results show partisan differences between Democrats and Republicans depending on the target of the

offensive or insulting statements. Likewise, Chong et al. (2024, p. 143), using a measure from McClosky and Brill (1983), found that conservatives are more tolerant than liberals of offensive speech targeting minorities and women but less tolerant of "unpopular or controversial left-wing opinions and ideas on nonracial topics" (Chong et al., 2024, pp. 141–43). Overall, existing research suggests that partisans differ in their support for speech restrictions, but the extent to which this support depends on the target of the speech or on how severe it is remains unclear.

The importance of separating severity from target characteristics is highlighted by previous public opinion research in other domains. Research on affective polarization (Druckman et al., 2022; Klar et al., 2018) and support for political violence (Westwood et al., 2022) has shown that reliance on abstract questions can lead to misleading inferences about public opinion. For example, Westwood et al. (2022) demonstrate that when researchers "ask about general support for violence without offering context, [the researchers] leave the respondent to infer what 'violence' means," which results in misleading inferences. Similarly, general questions about banning "offensive" language without specifying context or level of severity may complicate inferences about whether people support hate speech regulation because of its severity or its target. These challenges underscore the value of research designs that separate the effects of severity and target characteristics to yield credible inferences about public support for hate speech regulation. This article does not provide an empirical test of whether respondents presented with generic survey questions infer different levels of severity depending on the target group; this potential mechanism is beyond its scope. The aim is instead to separate the effects of speech severity and target characteristics on support for hate speech regulation.

Public Opinion and Hate Speech Regulation

Drawing on the literature, I outline three predictions about public demand for regulating hate speech. First, the severity of the speech matters; when severity increases, people are more supportive of regulating it. Second, the group being targeted matters; people may be willing to restrict hate speech directed at vulnerable or historically marginalized groups (e.g., racial or religious minorities). Third, popular support for hate speech regulation may be shaped through a partisan lens, such that partisans are more supportive of regulating hate speech directed at groups they sympathize with or believe deserve protection. I address these three accounts in turn.

Severity is a key feature in definitions of hate speech. Although there is no single definition of online hate speech (Article 19, 2015; Siegel, 2020, pp. 56–57), it generally portrays a group negatively and may range from offensive speech to threats and incitement to violence (Alkiviadou et al., 2020; Rossini, 2019; Siegel, 2020). The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in 1966, stipulates that "any advocacy of national, racial or religious hatred that constitutes incitement to discrimination, hostility or violence shall be prohibited by law" (ICCPR, 1966). Some types of hate speech may be lawful but still raise concerns about intolerance and discrimination, while other types of speech, such as dehumanization and degradation, can be unlawful (Article 19, 2015; Mchangama et al., 2021).

Empirical evidence also documents the effect of severity on public support for content moderation (Ashokkumar et al., 2020; Kozyreva et al., 2023; Pradel et al., 2024; Solomon et al., 2024), crowd moderation (Wilhelm et al., 2020; Skovgaard Jensen et al., 2026, pp. 3-9), and

regulation (Munzert et al., 2025). Perceived threat is a crucial factor when people judge whether statements are acceptable (Davis & Silver, 2004; Gibson, 2011; Marcus et al., 1995; Petersen et al., 2011). Most people perceive threatening statements and harassment as unacceptable in political discussions (Stryker et al., 2016), and Skytte (2022, p. 1746) finds that while copartisans tolerate milder forms of incivility, "a limit exists beyond which the rhetoric becomes too extreme for even the base."

Hypothesis 1: Severity increases support for hate speech regulation.

Hate speech laws are often introduced to protect social or demographic groups from harm (but see Mchangama, 2014), although which groups are legally protected from hate speech varies considerably across countries (for an overview, see Alkiviadou et al., 2020). Hate speech laws and content moderation policies on social media often protect groups based on race, ethnicity, or religion because they represent salient group markers within societies (Sellars, 2016, p. 25). As noted by Mchangama (2021, p. 20): "Given the long and bloody history of religious, ethnic and racial intolerance in Europe and the US, equality and non-discrimination are vital goods constituting cornerstones of liberal democratic societies. These fundamental principles are undermined when minority groups are subject to hatred and bigotry."

Evidence indicates that when people consider whether speech should be allowed, they often place considerable emphasis on the groups targeted. Recent evidence shows that people are more supportive of social media platforms removing hate speech targeting certain minorities and historically marginalized groups (Munzert et al., 2025; Solomon et al., 2024). Public opinion

tends to emphasize racial, ethnic, and religious group markers in the regulation of hate speech. Chong et al. (2024) argue that there has been a "dramatic realignment in public tolerance of offensive expression about race, gender, and religious groups," suggesting that the public increasingly supports regulating hate speech targeting minority groups. Moreover, Eady and Rasmussen (2025, p. 1446) find that politicians and citizens "regard messages targeting women politicians as more toxic than otherwise equivalent messages targeting men." This suggests that target characteristics may play an important role in shaping public opinion on hate speech regulation.

> *Hypothesis 2*: Statements targeting groups based on gender, race, national origin, or religion increase support for hate speech regulation compared to statements that do not mention an identity group.[1]

Partisans have different opinions about *whom* hate speech laws should protect. People on the political left and right identify with different social groups (Finkel et al., 2020; Mason, 2018) and have different views of which groups are vulnerable to harm (Crawford, 2017; Gray & Kubin, 2024; Womick et al., 2024). For example, Democrats in the U.S. are more supportive of protecting minority groups (Chong et al., 2024, p. 143; Moore, 2015; Poushter, 2015; Skaaning & Krishnarajan, 2025, p. 31; Solomon et al., 2024, p. 4). In contrast, right-leaning partisans show

[1] To align the hypothesis with the reference category used in the analysis, the hypothesis deviates from the preregistration, as it uses "no identity group" rather than "political groups" as the reference category. The preregistered hypothesis reads: "Statements targeting groups based on gender, race, national origin, or religion compared to statements targeting political groups increase support for hate speech regulation."

greater opposition to hate speech prohibitions. Research shows that conservatism and Republican party identification predict social dominance orientation (Pratto et al., 1994, pp. 754–55), which has been found to predict acceptance of hate speech targeting minorities (Bilewicz et al., 2017). Evidence also shows that partisanship predicts perceptions of hostile rhetoric (Druckman et al., 2019; Gervais, 2015; Muddiman, 2017; Skytte, 2022; Stevens et al., 2015), censorship (Ashokkumar et al., 2020; Lelkes & Westwood, 2016), and dehumanization of out-partisans (Martherus et al., 2021; Moore-Berg et al., 2020). Taken together, these findings provide reason to expect partisanship to shape public support for regulating hate speech.[2]

Hypothesis 3: Partisanship moderates the effect of severity and target characteristics on support for hate speech regulation.

Research Design

To study the factors shaping support for restricting hate speech, two conjoint experiments were fielded in the U.S. and Denmark. Conjoint experiments make it possible to disentangle the relative influence of multiple attributes (e.g., severity and target characteristics) of social media 3s on support for regulating hate speech (Bansak et al., 2021; Hainmueller et al., 2014). The causal quantity of interest in conjoint experiments is the average marginal component effect (AMCE). The AMCE for each attribute is the marginal effect of seeing a particular attribute level in a

[2] H3 corresponds to H8 ("Partisanship moderates the effect on perceived offensiveness, perception of legality, and preference for legality") and is further specified under exploratory analyses in the preregistration. The article deviates from the preregistration in order to focus on public support for regulating hate speech. See Figures S19–S20 in Section E of the appendix for all preregistered analyses with auxiliary outcomes.

statement, relative to the baseline, on the preference for restricting a statement, averaged across all other possible combinations of statement attributes (Hainmueller et al., 2014). For example, it allows researchers to estimate the average causal effect on support for hate speech regulation when the speech is directed at Muslims compared with Christians.

The conjoint experiments were fielded in two national samples in Denmark and the U.S. The survey agency YouGov conducted 1,518 interviews in the U.S. and 1,535 interviews in Denmark between February 2 and 9, 2021. YouGov sampled from its internet panels and employed quota sampling to match population characteristics on age, gender, race (for the U.S. sample), region, and education. All analyses use weights based on these dimensions (see Section B of the appendix). Respondents were excluded if they did not answer the main outcome question in any task of the conjoint experiment (147 in Denmark and 110 in the U.S.). The final sample was 1,388 respondents in Denmark and 1,408 in the U.S. *Preregistration*, *questionnaire*, and other *materials* are available on the Open Science Framework: https://osf.io/7xvq6/overview.

Publics in Denmark and the U.S. generally support freedom of expression (Skaaning & Krishnarajan, 2025), but the two countries differ in two respects that are relevant to support for hate speech regulation. First, they differ in their legal frameworks for restricting freedom of expression, including hate speech (Bleich, 2014). Both countries restrict freedom of expression when expressions incite violence or imminent lawless action. However, below this threshold, Danish law is more restrictive of hate speech targeting certain characteristics (see Table S4 in the appendix for an overview). While U.S. law relies solely on the severity of the speech, Danish law is more closely aligned with the legal framework of the European Union. For example, at the time

of data collection, section 266b of the Danish Criminal Code restricted speech by which "a group of people are threatened, insulted or degraded on account of their race, skin colour, national or ethnic origin, religious belief, or because of their sexual orientation" (Justitsministeriet, 2021). However, in neither country were there restrictions on speech targeting groups based on political beliefs, disabilities, age, or social status.[3] Some theories argue that criminal laws primarily originate from a common set of intuitions of justice (Sznycer & Patrick, 2020), but an alternative perspective suggests that national variation in laws may reflect political culture and norms (Bleich, 2014, pp. 297-298). If the latter is the case, we should expect larger target effects in Denmark. Thus, using Denmark and the U.S. as cases provides an opportunity to study the alignment between public opinion and existing laws in different legal contexts.

Second, the U.S. is considered a polarized context (Iyengar et al., 2019). This study advances the extensive literature on the origins and consequences of polarization, including the relationship between polarization and partisan hostility (Amira et al., 2021; Iyengar & Westwood, 2015; Lelkes & Westwood, 2016; Westwood et al., 2022), by examining preferences for regulating hate speech against political, religious, gendered, or ethnic groups in countries with varying levels of polarization. For instance, if polarization matters for regulating hate speech, partisans should be less (more) restrictive when hate speech targets out-group (in-group) members. In sum, Americans likely live in a more politically polarized society with fewer restrictions on freedom of expression than Danes. Consequently, Denmark and the U.S. provide an opportunity to assess support for hate speech regulation across distinct legal frameworks and levels of polarization.

[3] Since the data collection, the following characteristics have been added to section 266b of the Danish Criminal Code: disability, gender identity, gender expression, and gender characteristics.

Stimuli

Table 1 shows a simplified version of the experimental setup (see Table S3 in Section A of the appendix for a detailed description of all attributes). Seven attributes were manipulated in the vignettes, and all were randomly assigned. The first four attributes in Table 1 were manipulated as text, whereas the latter three were incorporated into contextual elements such as the profile picture, the individual's name, and the nature of the conversation (public/private). All attribute levels had equal probability (uniform distribution) except for the ethnicity of the sender (majority/minority), as this attribute by definition entails an unequal real-world distribution. To better reflect the actual demographic proportions in the U.S. and Denmark, an 80/20 split was used (De la Cuesta et al., 2022).

The analysis focuses on two key attributes relevant to evaluating the hypotheses: (1) the severity of the speech and (2) the target of the statement. The severity of statements was manipulated by presenting participants with four types of hate speech through eight statements: (1) incivility, (2) degradation and dehumanization without a direct threat, (3) degradation and dehumanization with a threat, and (4) incitement to violence.[4] This conceptualization builds on past work on incivility (Druckman et al., 2019; Skytte, 2022), toxic speech (Eady & Rasmussen, 2025; Petersen et al., 2024; Rasmussen 2026), and content moderation (Munzert et al., 2025; Pradel et al., 2024; Solomon et al., 2024). The hierarchical progression in severity also reflects definitions of hate speech in international and national legal frameworks (Article 19, 2015, pp.

[4] I preregistered the severity types as "Incivility, dehumanization, degradation, and call for violence" and noted that two of the statements categorized under degradation and dehumanization "contain elements that can be interpreted as an incitement to violence." In the analysis, I grouped the threatening severity types to reflect the hierarchical structure of severity.

18–22; United Nations, 2012, p. 13). Crucially, it makes it possible to separate the effects of severity and target characteristics across varying degrees of severity. Moreover, it enables testing whether variations in severity condition the effects of target characteristics (Druckman et al., 2019, p. 295).

Next, *the target of* the statement was manipulated. Specifically, groups were included along political lines (left-wing/right-wing), religion (Christian/Muslim), ethnicity (Black/White in the U.S., Danes/immigrants in Denmark), and gender (male/female), as these are central to legal and public understandings of hate speech (Alkiviadou et al., 2020, pp. 3-12; Howard, 2019, p. 95; Siegel, 2020, pp. 56-59).

Five additional attributes were included to mimic political posts on social media and to capture potential effects based on context, message, and sender. First, the *target type* was manipulated so that the statement targeted either politicians or voters. Previous research has examined perceptions of toxic behaviors such as incivility, intolerance, and hate speech directed at politicians (Eady & Rasmussen, 2025). Partisans have more negative feelings toward politicians of the opposing party than toward its voters (Druckman & Levendusky, 2019; Kingzette, 2021). Varying the target type (politicians/voters) makes it possible to test whether citizens are more restrictive of hate speech toward voters than toward politicians.

Second, the valence of the targeted issue position (e.g., support for or opposition to affirmative action) was manipulated to make it possible to assess whether people selectively supported regulating ideas they disagreed with. Research shows that "supporters of a political cause (e.g., abortion or gun rights) preferentially censored comments that opposed their cause" (Ashokkumar et al., 2020, p. 1). Similarly, Crawford and Pilanski (2014, p. 849) found that "both

liberals and conservatives were intolerant of those with whom they disagreed." If this is true, we should expect a person who supports affirmative action programs to be more restrictive when hate speech targets people who support such policies.

Table 1: Experimental setup

Attribute	**Levels**
Severity	***Incivility*** I'm so sick of … They're a bunch of idiots who are tearing our country apart! The most detrimental group to American society are … Their worldview is as inhumane and oppressive as the Nazis! ***Dehumanization/Degradation (not threatening)*** I'm fed up with … They're a bunch of retards with an IQ of 75! I've had enough of … If you ask me, they're worthless pigs! ***Dehumanization/Degradation (threatening)*** There is a certain similarity between vermin and … Let's exterminate both! Any volunteers who want to take on that task? It's nauseating listening to … Find these inferior people and send them off to rot on a desert island! ***Incitement to violence*** I've had enough of … These people are a cancer to American society and must be wiped off the face of the earth! I just started collecting names of … Those kinds of people deserve a bullet to the head!
Target Groups	[No identity group]
	Political: Democratic/Republican Religious: Christian/Muslim Ethnic: White/Black Gender: Female/Male
Target type	Voters, Politicians
Issue Position	[No issue position] Support/Oppose: Affirmative Action Support/Oppose: Harsher Punishment Support/Oppose: Abortion Support/Oppose: Adoption by Same-Sex Couples
Sender Gender	Male, Female
Sender Ethnicity	Majority, Minority
Publicness	Public Statement, Private Conversation

Note: This table shows a simplified version of the experimental setup for the conjoint experiment. Detailed information including probabilities can be found in Section A of the appendix.

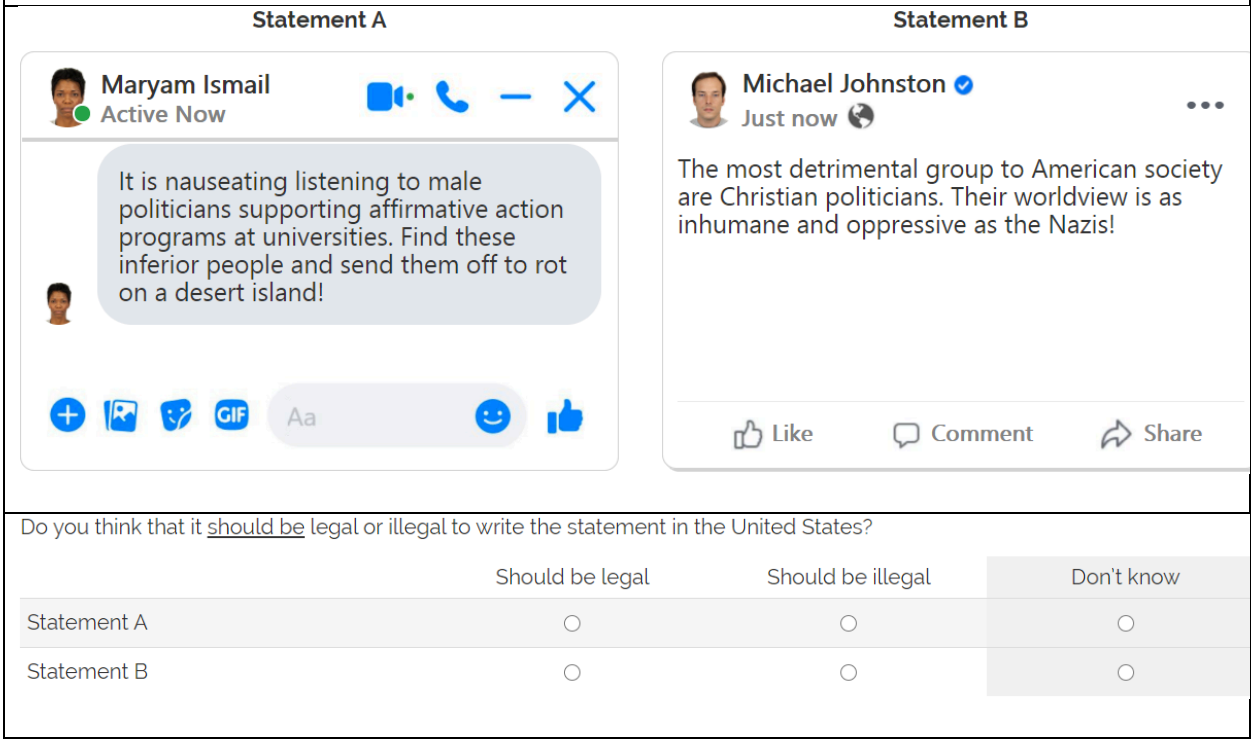
Third, the gender and ethnicity of the sender were varied, as prior research suggests that these attributes can shape public evaluations of speech. For example, Eady and Rasmussen (2025, p. 1456) show how "toxic messages sent to a woman politician are deemed more toxic if it is sent by a user [who] is a man rather than a woman." Lindner and Nosek (2009, p. 86) find mixed evidence regarding Americans' willingness to restrict speech based on the speaker's ethnicity. To capture potential effects of sender characteristics, the study varied them using profile images and names that signaled the sender's gender and whether they belonged to an ethnic majority or minority. For the Danish experiment, profile images were drawn from the Oslo Face Database (Chelnokova et al., 2014), while the American experiment used images from the Chicago Face Database (Ma et al., 2015).

Fourth, the publicness of the statement was manipulated. Previous research indicates that public hate speech is perceived as more offensive and that speakers are held more accountable for public speech (Cowan & Hodge, 1996, p. 366). The present study therefore manipulated whether the statement was disseminated in a public social media post or a private message.

The number of attributes introduces complexity and potential threats to causal interpretation. For instance, estimated effects may be conditional on sender characteristics or the presence of issue positions. A series of robustness checks in the supplementary material demonstrates that the results hold across alternative specifications. These include re-estimating the main model while conditioning on sender ethnicity (Figures S3–S4), severity levels across partisanship (Figure S2), and profile position (Figures S6–S7), as well as excluding profiles with issue positions (Figure S5).

The study used a paired vignette design in which participants saw two social media posts at a time (Bansak et al., 2021; Hainmueller et al., 2015). The vignettes resemble typical content on social media platforms (Munzert et al., 2025). A limitation of the design is that it does not simulate a complete social media feed, which may affect its ecological validity (Mutz, 2011). Figure 1 shows a paired vignette task. Each participant repeated the task eight times, rating a total of 16 statements.

Figure 1: Example of paired vignette task



Measures

The main outcome of interest, support for hate speech regulation, was assessed using a rating outcome, which is among "the two most common measures of stated preference in political science applications of conjoint designs" (Bansak et al., 2021, p. 27). The main advantage is that a rating outcome enables estimation of the absolute level of support for restriction, unlike

forced-choice designs, which only capture relative preferences. Participants were asked to respond to the following question: "Do you think that it should be legal or illegal to write the statement in [the U.S./Denmark]?" (see Figure 1). Response options included "Should be legal," "Should be illegal," and "Don't know." "Don't know" responses were excluded from the analysis. Figure S18 in the appendix replicates the main results with "Don't know" coded as the midpoint on the scale (0.5). Bansak et al. (2021, p. 28) recommend eliciting preferences through multiple measures. Accordingly, three additional outcomes were preregistered: (1) a choice-based measure of perceived offensiveness ("Which of the two statements do you find most offensive?"), (2) a rating-based measure of perceived offensiveness ("On a scale from 1 to 7, where 1 indicates that the statement is not at all offensive and 7 indicates that the statement is extremely offensive, how would you rate [Statement A/Statement B]?"), and (3) a measure of perceived legality ("Do you think that it is legal or illegal to write the statement in [the U.S./Denmark]?"). All preregistered analyses related to these outcomes are reported in Figures S19–S20 in the appendix.

To measure partisanship, standard measures from the American (ANES) and Danish (DNES) National Election Studies were used. Based on answers to the question of whether participants saw themselves as supporters of a specific party, they were categorized as either Republican, Independent, or Democrat in the U.S. and either left-wing or right-wing in Denmark. Respondents who did not report supporting or leaning toward a specific party were not included in the analyses of heterogeneous effects across partisan groups.

Results

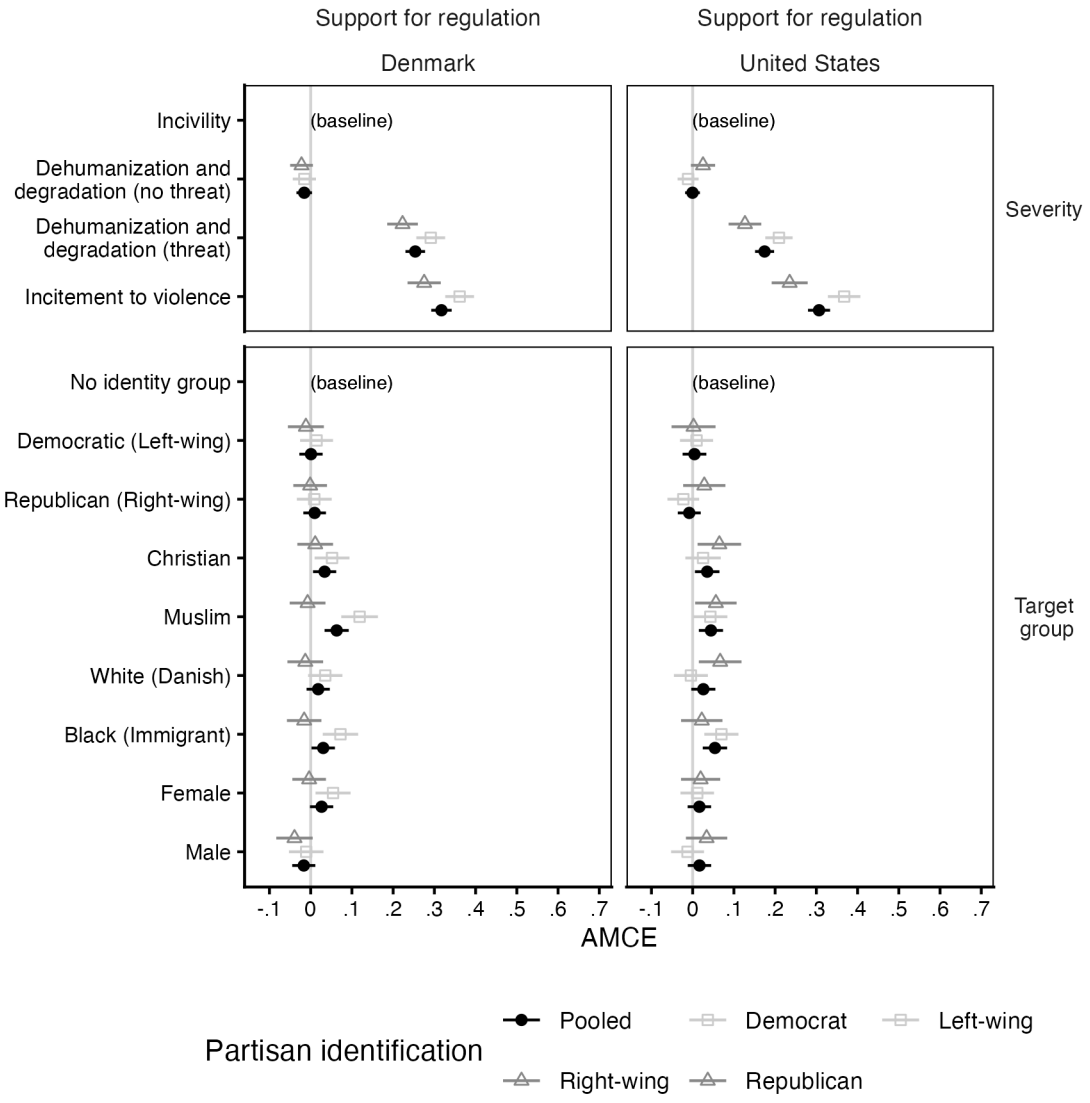
The Effects of Target Characteristics

I begin the analysis by separating the effects of target characteristics and severity on support for hate speech laws. To this end, I estimate the average marginal component effect (AMCE) of each target group and severity level.[5] Positive values indicate that a specific attribute level increases support for regulation (see Figure 2). On average, support for hate speech restrictions in Denmark and the U.S. increases by 3 to 6.3 percentage points when hate speech targets religious groups (Christians and Muslims) and ethnic minorities (Black people in the U.S. and immigrants in Denmark) relative to statements that do not mention an identity group. The largest effects of target characteristics in Denmark are observed for statements targeting Muslims, which increase support for regulation by 6.3 percentage points. In the U.S., hate speech targeting Black people increases support by 5.4 percentage points. In both countries, the second-largest target effects are for statements targeting Christians, which increase support for regulation by 3.5 (U.S.) and 3.4 percentage points (Denmark). These results suggest that the public is, on average, more supportive of hate speech laws when speech targets Muslims, Christians, and ethnic minorities. Figure 2 also displays the effects of severity. It shows that, compared with incivility, threatening dehumanization or degradation and incitement to violence increase support for hate speech regulation by 25.3 and 32 percentage points, respectively, in Denmark and by 17.4 and 31 percentage points in the U.S. The overall pattern is that people primarily support regulating hate speech when it amounts to threats and incitement to violence, whereas they do not seem to

[5] I present the two key attributes, severity and target characteristics, in the main text to evaluate the key hypotheses and report all preregistered analyses of the other attributes in the appendix (Figures S19-S20).

differentiate between incivility and degradation or dehumanization that falls short of direct threats or incitement to violence.

Figure 2: Average marginal component effects (AMCEs) of severity and target characteristics across partisans in Denmark and the U.S.



Note: Points are OLS estimates with 95% confidence interval bars based on clustered standard errors at the respondent level, controlling for *issue position*, *publicness*, *target type*, *sender gender,* and *sender ethnicity*. The pooled sample contains 18,655 observations (1,388 respondents) in Denmark and 19,130 observations (1,408 respondents) in the U.S. Partisan subgroups: Denmark: 8,403 observations among 627 left-wing partisans; 7,724 observations among 547 right-wing partisans. U.S.: 9,736 observations among 714 Democrats and 6,002 observations among 428 Republicans. See Table S7 in the appendix for the full model output.

While statistically significant effects of target characteristics are in the range of 3 to 6.3 percentage points, we might expect target characteristics to have heterogeneous effects across partisan groups and levels of severity. In the following, I examine four plausible empirical patterns.

Are partisans more supportive of regulating hate speech targeting their political in-group or less supportive when it targets their political opponents? The results indicate that they are not. In Figure 2, the rows with "Democratic (Left-wing)" and "Republican (Right-wing)" provide evidence on this question. They show null effects for partisans in Denmark and the U.S. This suggests that partisans were neither more nor less likely to support hate speech regulation when it targeted their political allies or opponents than when no identity group was mentioned. These findings contrast with research suggesting that partisans selectively accept or oppose hostility conditional on its political motivation (Kalmoe & Mason, 2022; Lelkes & Westwood, 2016; Westwood et al., 2022). Thus, the findings provide no evidence that partisans distinguish between hate speech targeting their fellow partisans and the opposing party.

Are partisans more supportive of regulating hate speech targeting ethnic, gender, or religious groups they sympathize with? Figure 2 provides some evidence in support of this proposition, as target characteristics have heterogeneous effects across partisan groups in Denmark and the U.S. In the U.S., Democrats are 6.9 percentage points more supportive of hate speech restrictions when speech targets Black people and 4.2 percentage points more supportive when it targets Muslims. By comparison, Republican support for hate speech restrictions increases by 6.5 percentage points when speech targets Christians, by 5.6 percentage points when it targets Muslims, and by 6.6 percentage points when it targets White people. This

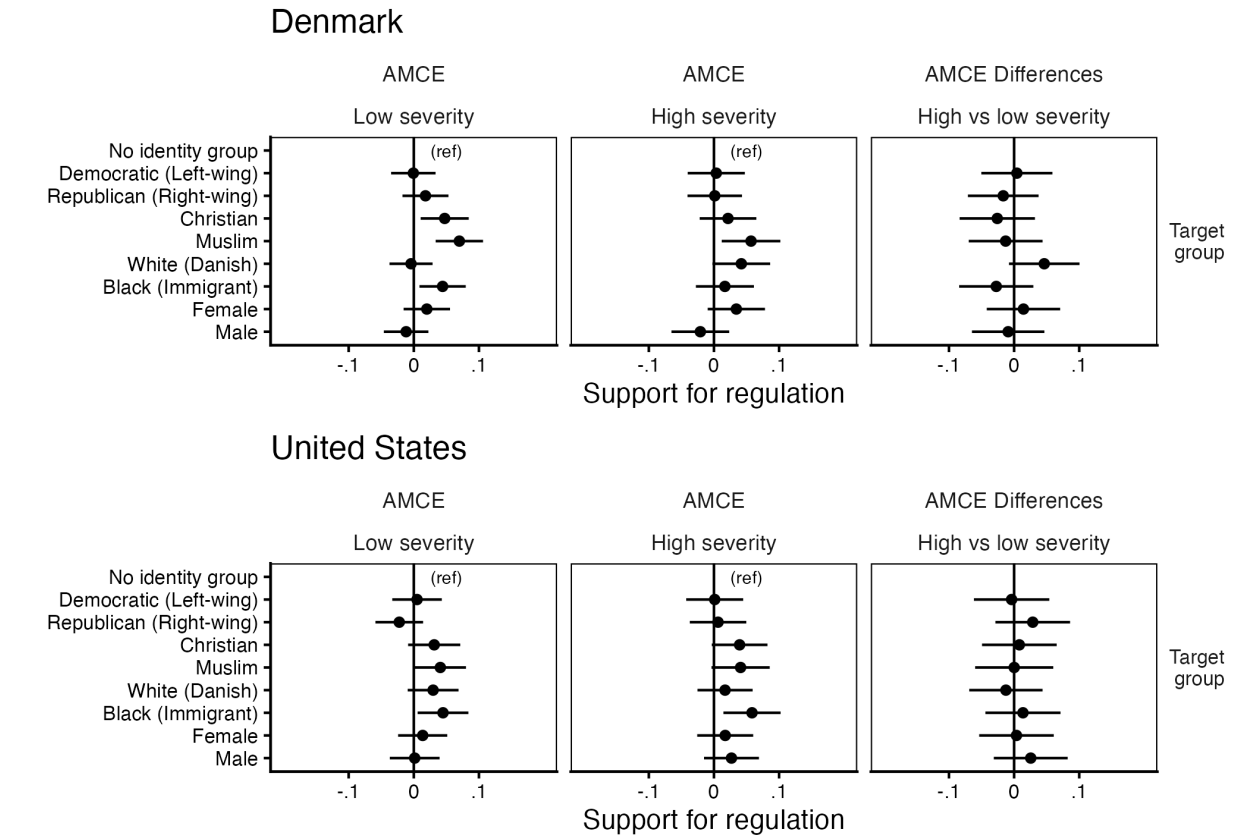
indicates cross-partisan alignment on hate speech regulation when statements target Muslims in the U.S. However, whereas Democrats are more supportive of restrictions when speech targets Black people, a historically marginalized ethnic group, Republicans are more supportive of restrictions when speech targets Christians and White people, who belong to religious and ethnic majority groups.

In Denmark, the effects of target characteristics are also heterogeneous: they are more pronounced among left-wing partisans, who are more supportive of hate speech restrictions when speech targets people based on religious, ethnic, and gender characteristics. Specifically, their support increases by 11.9 percentage points when hate speech targets Muslims, 7.2 percentage points when it targets immigrants, 5.4 percentage points when it targets women, and 5.2 percentage points when it targets Christians. In contrast, there are no statistically significant effects of target characteristics among right-wing partisans in Denmark. Overall, target characteristics have heterogeneous effects across partisan groups in both Denmark and the U.S.

Does the effect of target characteristics depend on the level of severity? The results suggest that it does not. Figure 3 shows the conditional effects of target characteristics. The left panel shows the AMCEs at low severity, while the center panel shows the AMCEs at high severity. The right panel makes it possible to assess directly whether the AMCEs for target characteristics vary across levels of severity. The results show no statistically significant differences in AMCEs between low and high severity. This suggests that the effects of target characteristics on support for hate speech regulation are broadly stable and do not vary systematically between low- and high-severity conditions. In other words, the effects of target characteristics persist when

severity is held constant, and the evidence does not suggest that they depend on the level of severity.

Figure 3: The effects of target characteristics are broadly stable at low and high levels of severity in Denmark and the U.S.



Note: Points are OLS estimates with 95% confidence interval bars based on clustered standard errors at the respondent level. Estimates are based on 18,655 observations (1,388 respondents) in Denmark and 19,130 observations (1,408 respondents) in the U.S. To ease interpretation, severity is collapsed into two levels: low severity, comprising incivility and non-threatening dehumanization/degradation, and high severity, comprising threatening dehumanization/degradation and incitement to violence. See Table S8 in the appendix for the full model output.

Does the effect of target characteristics depend on the level of severity among partisans? The results indicate that it does not. One might expect the effect of target groups to be stronger at higher levels of severity among partisans. For example, Democrats might be especially likely to

support restricting threatening hate speech against Black people. This was tested with a three-way interaction between severity, target group, and partisanship. The results do not support this proposition, as none of the interaction terms were statistically significant (see Figure S2).

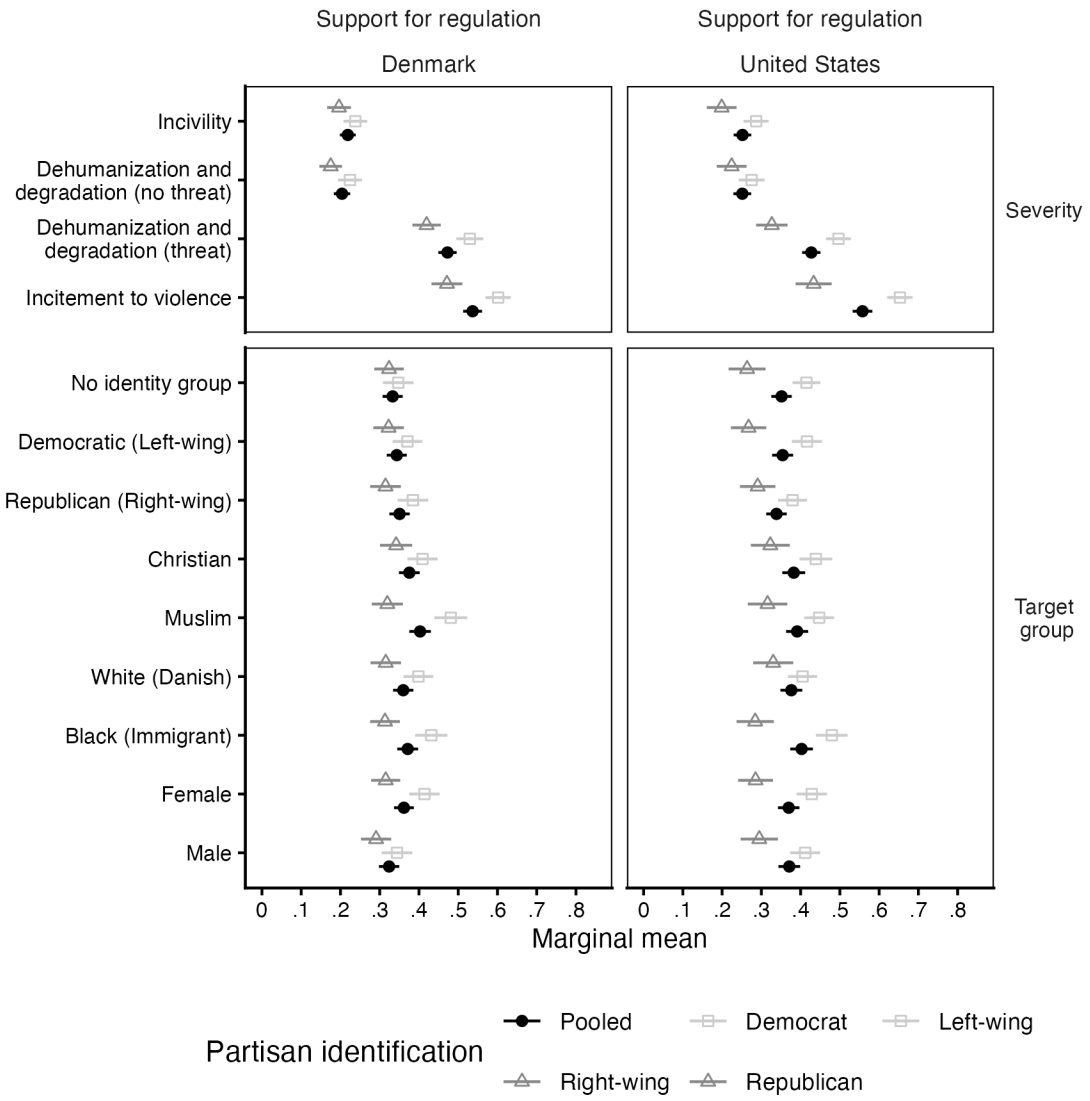
Overall, the results suggest that severity and target characteristics have independent effects on support for hate speech regulation. Although the effect of severity is substantially larger, the effect of target characteristics persists when severity is held constant and is largest when speech targets religious and ethnic groups. The persistence of target effects when severity is held constant suggests that they are not wholly attributable to severity. Moreover, partisans are neither more nor less supportive of hate speech regulation when it targets their political in-group or out-group. Finally, the effects of target characteristics on support for hate speech regulation are broadly similar at low and high levels of severity.

Support for Hate Speech Regulation

Having separated the effects of target characteristics and severity on support for hate speech regulation, I now turn to the overall level of support. Figure 4 shows marginal means, which correspond to the average support for regulating a statement with a specific attribute (e.g., targeting Muslims) for each subgroup (e.g., Democrats). In other words, Figure 4 describes the overall demand for making statements illegal in both the U.S. and Denmark (see Table S9 in the appendix for all estimates). Notably, a majority support regulation only when statements include direct incitement to violence. Turning to differences across the political spectrum, Figure 4 shows that people on the political left are on average more supportive of hate speech regulation than those on the right. Moreover, partisan differences in support for hate speech restrictions are greater in the U.S. than in Denmark, particularly at higher levels of severity. The partisan

differences in support for regulation increase with content severity in both countries. In other words, severity has a larger effect on left-wing partisans and Democrats than on right-wing partisans and Republicans. For target characteristics, the largest partisan differences in marginal means are observed when statements target Muslims in Denmark and Black people in the U.S.

Figure 4: Support for regulating hate speech across partisanship in Denmark and the U.S.



Note: Points are OLS estimates with 95% confidence interval bars based on clustered standard errors at the respondent level, controlling for *issue position*, *publicness*, *target type*, *sender gender,* and *sender ethnicity*. The pooled sample contains 18,655 observations (1,388 respondents) in Denmark and 19,130 observations (1,408 respondents) in the U.S. The partisan subgroups comprise 8,403 observations (627 left-wing partisans) and 7,724 observations (547 right-wing partisans) in Denmark, and 9,736 observations (714 Democrats) and 6,002 observations (428 Republicans) in the U.S. See Table S9 in the appendix for the full model output.

Discussion

While hate speech laws are being introduced around the globe (Parekh, 2012, p. 37), evidence on the extent to which public support for such laws depends on the target of hate speech or on its severity remains limited. This article contributes by estimating the independent effects of severity and target characteristics on support for hate speech laws through conjoint experiments fielded in Denmark and the U.S. The results show that when severity increases from incivility to incitement to violence, support for hate speech regulation increases by up to 32 percentage points. Target characteristics have smaller but non-zero effects that are heterogeneous across target groups and partisan groups. These effects are broadly stable across low and high levels of severity. In other words, the effect of target characteristics persists when the level of severity is held constant. On average, support for hate speech regulation changes by up to 6.3 percentage points depending on the target in Denmark and the U.S. The effects are largest when hate speech targets religious groups (Christians and Muslims) and ethnic minorities (Black people in the U.S., immigrants in Denmark). This suggests that people in Denmark and the U.S. are more supportive of regulating hate speech targeting certain groups. There is variation across partisan groups, as the effects of target characteristics are more pronounced for some partisans when hate speech targets certain religious or ethnic minority groups. With one exception, statistically significant effect sizes among partisans range from 3 to 7.2 percentage points. The exception is among left-wing respondents in Denmark, whose support for regulation increases by 11.9 percentage points when statements target Muslims. Finally, I find no evidence that partisans are more supportive of regulating hate speech targeting their political opponents than of hate speech targeting their political allies.

The findings speak to concerns about the adverse consequences of polarization among partisans (Lelkes & Westwood, 2016; Westwood et al., 2022). In short, partisans in both countries are no more willing to regulate hate speech targeting their political opponents than to regulate hate speech targeting their political allies. This contribution is important, as previous research suggests that partisans harbor negative feelings about their political opponents (Iyengar et al., 2012, 2019) and are more willing to tolerate and support preferential treatment of in-partisans (Lelkes & Westwood, 2016, p. 498), particularly when their partisan identity is threatened (Amira et al., 2021, pp. 473–74). This article provides no evidence that partisans apply different standards when regulating hate speech targeting political opponents versus political allies.

The main focus of the article, severity and target characteristics, is central to public debates about regulating hate speech (Kaye, 2021). The experiments also tested whether people were more likely to support regulation when hate speech targeted individuals (voters or politicians) holding certain opinions (e.g., opposing affirmative action), whether the speech was public or private, and whether the sender's gender and ethnicity influenced responses. Overall, the results showed limited or null effects of these attributes (see Figure S20 in the appendix; see Figures S8–S15 for an extensive test of heterogeneity by issue position). These findings align with previous research showing minimal effects of source cues on support for content moderation (Feezell et al., 2023; Kozyreva et al., 2023; Munzert et al., 2025; Solomon et al., 2024) and censorship (Carlos et al., 2023; Dias et al., 2025) but contradict studies suggesting that partisans censor political out-groups (Ashokkumar et al., 2020). An important difference is that many of these studies examine content moderation, whereas this article focuses on support for hate speech regulation. Future studies should compare differences in support for platform

moderation, national legislation, and other types of moderation such as crowd moderation. The results also show that publicness had no effect on support for hate speech regulation, despite broad dissemination typically being considered an aggravating factor (Alkiviadou et al., 2020). While this result is consistent with findings that the number of followers does not influence support for moderating misinformation (Kozyreva et al., 2023), future research is warranted to further test this proposition.

The study adds to a burgeoning literature on public opinion about regulation and content moderation (Ashokkumar et al., 2020; Dias et al., 2025; Kozyreva et al., 2023; Munzert et al., 2025; Pradel et al., 2024; Solomon et al., 2024; Wilhelm et al., 2020) but naturally has limitations that merit investigation. One limitation concerns the question of why some individuals are more supportive of regulating hate speech directed at certain groups. For example, why are Democrats more supportive of regulating hate speech targeting Black people? A prominent explanation is that liberals tend to place greater emphasis on fairness and the prevention of harm (Graham et al., 2009; Gray & Kubin, 2024; Van Bavel et al., 2024, pp. 328-329). Recent research supports the view that people are more likely to support censorship when they perceive content as harmful (Boch, 2020; Crawford, 2017; Kubin et al., 2025; Womick et al., 2024). Relatedly, a large literature in political science has shown that the major political parties in the U.S. have "sorted in terms of ideological identity and demography" (Finkel et al., 2020, p. 534). This attachment to and alignment with specific groups may shape support for speech restrictions. Another perspective suggests that support for regulating hate speech arises from concerns about its role in perpetuating social inequalities affecting historically marginalized groups (Sidanius & Pratto, 2001). Indeed, research has shown that a preference for group-based dominance is associated

with racism, sexism, and prejudice (Kunst et al., 2017), dehumanization of refugees and immigrants (Costello & Hodson, 2011; Esses et al., 2008; Kteily et al., 2015), and even acceptance of hate speech (Bilewicz et al., 2017). Conversely, some argue that opposition to hate speech regulation stems from principled conservatism and a general resistance to government intervention (Grossmann & Hopkins, 2015; Sniderman et al., 1996).

This study contributes by disentangling the effect of target characteristics from the severity of the content and estimating their independent causal impact on support for hate speech regulation. The design manipulates different levels of severity (e.g., incivility and incitement to violence) through concrete statements (e.g., "I'm so sick of [group]! They're a bunch of idiots who are tearing our country apart!"), which makes it possible to show that target characteristics have independent effects that are not wholly attributable to severity. However, the design does not test whether respondents presented with generic survey questions (e.g., "offensive to [group]") infer different levels of severity depending on the target group. Future research should test this potential mechanism by comparing generic questions with conditions in which severity is explicitly fixed.

The conjoint experiments were designed to capture a wide range of typical hate speech targets at varying levels of severity in two countries with distinct socio-political contexts, thereby enhancing the generalizability of the findings. However, three issues warrant further investigation. First, the experiments were designed so that each severity statement (incivility; degradation/dehumanization without threat; degradation/dehumanization with threat; incitement to violence) could apply to each target to allow for valid inferences. This design facilitates the estimation of average marginal component effects (AMCEs) for both severity and

target groups in relation to typical forms of hate speech. However, it may overlook idiosyncratic forms of hate speech that might be perceived as more or less severe depending on the target group. The study focused on typical forms of hate speech, but future research could explore these variations by considering a wider range of hate speech forms, including forms that might be uniquely severe for particular groups. Second, the inferences drawn from the study are constrained by the specific target groups included in the experiments. For example, it is plausible that the political right in Denmark and the U.S. might show stronger support for regulating hate speech directed at targets not represented in the experiment (e.g., national symbols such as the flag). Future research should continue to assess citizens' support for speech restrictions across different target groups and institutional contexts. Third, although the conjoint experiments used vignettes to mimic what people experience on social media, the design is still limited by not embedding these vignettes in real social media feeds, which may constrain the external validity of the findings. Future research should seek to address this limitation and improve the external validity of the findings.

Overall, this study demonstrates that severity is the main driver of support for hate speech regulation. Target characteristics also have smaller but non-zero effects, particularly when hate speech targets ethnic or religious groups. These effects of target characteristics persist when severity is held constant and broadly similar across levels of severity. In both the U.S. and Denmark, partisans differ in their overall support for hate speech regulation and, to some extent, in which target groups they are most inclined to protect.

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Competing Interests

The author declares no competing interests.

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AI Statement

In preparing this manuscript, the author used Claude for copyediting to improve the clarity and consistency of the manuscript. The author maintains full responsibility for the final content.

Ethics Statement

As per Section 14(2) of the act underlying the Danish National Research Ethics Committee, "notification of questionnaire surveys … to the system of research ethics committee system is only required if the project involves human biological material." The Research Ethics Committee (Institutional Review Board) confirmed that the study complies with the ethical standards of Aarhus University (BSS-2023-023). Informed consent was obtained from all participants.

Data Availability

The data, code, and any additional materials required to replicate all analyses in this article is available on the Open Science Framework: https://osf.io/7xvq6/overview.

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